Assignment Report
Assignment 2
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1. System

Our group project focuses on designing an application to help exchange students at USI organise their semester more effectively. The application aims to support students in selecting courses and understanding whether the credits they earn will be recognised by their home university.

It also addresses other challenges that exchange students may face during their stay, such as overlapping exam dates, fragmented university IT services (e.g., iCorsi and GestU), and difficulties finding reliable information about timetables and lecture rooms. The overall goal is to make semester planning easier and reduce the uncertainty associated with studying at a foreign university.

2. Range of user characteristics

Academic background

- Study programme and year of study
- Academic goals and motivation
- Home university requirements for credit recognition
- Previous experience with exchange programmes

Personal background

- Age
- Country of origin
- Languages spoken
- Cultural and academic differences between home and host universities

Lifestyle and availability

- Working or not working during the exchange
- Time available for studying
- Length of exchange period
- Other commitments and interests

Needs and behaviours

- Course selection and semester planning habits
- Preferred ways of accessing university information
- Familiarity with USI's digital services
- Main frustrations and difficulties
- Need for guidance and support

Description

Potential users include exchange students from different study programmes and years of study. They may also differ in their academic goals and motivation. For example, some students may prioritise achieving high grades, while others may focus on fulfilling the minimum requirements of their exchange programme and successfully transferring their credits.

Students may also have different academic and cultural backgrounds, language skills, and home university requirements. These differences can influence how they select courses, understand university procedures, and approach credit recognition.

Furthermore, students may have different time constraints depending on their workload, employment, and other commitments. Their previous experience with exchange programmes and digital university services may also influence how much guidance they need when organising their semester.

3. Persona



Serena, 23
USI Faculty of Economy (Mobility), Italy, Bologna

Background:
Serena will go on her second Erasmus+ exchange, this time she is visiting USI Faculty of Economics in Lugano. She is a good student and likes to have some order in the things she does. This is her second Erasmus+ so this time she knows how to be properly prepared for the next study exchange.

She needs to select courses that fit both the exchange semester in terms of credit minimum and recognition at her own home university in Bologna. She e-mailed her professors to get an idea if the syllabuses of the courses she wants to take are on par with the home equivalents. She mostly got responses saying that they'll allow it for now but their decision can still change when she arrives to Lugano and sends them the "official" syllabus. Serena is stressed a little about this uncertainty.

Goals

- Get to know people from different backgrounds and experience different culture for her own self-growing benefit.
- Choose suitable courses and ensure that credits can be recognised.
- Plan the semester without unexpected scheduling conflicts.
- Study during the exchange. (Hard worker)

Needs

- Make a friend who she can study with and talk.

Frustrations

- Uncertainty about which courses will be accepted by the home university.
- Potential conflicts between exam dates and other academic commitments.

Process

I developed the persona using the transcribed interview data collected by my group. I considered the participants' academic backgrounds, goals, needs, and difficulties when organising their exchange semester. I then looked for recurring patterns and compared the participants' experiences to identify characteristics relevant to our system.
Based on these findings, I selected the characteristics that were most relevant to the design problem and combined them into one fictional user profile.